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A Palestinian girl walks past a destroyed building following overnight Israeli strikes on a residential area in Jabalia's southwestern district of Nazla in the northern Gaza Strip.

Israel says it will block all humanitarian aid into Gaza

Relentless military offensive has turned Palestinian territory into a 'mass grave'

JERUSALEM

Israel said yesterday it would keep blocking humanitarian aid from entering Gaza, where a relentless military offensive has turned the Palestinian territory into a "mass grave", a medical charity reported.

Air and ground attacks resumed across the Gaza Strip from March 18, ending a two-month ceasefire with Hamas that had largely halted hostilities in the territory.

However, Israel has halted the entry of aid into Gaza since March 2, as the humanitarian crisis continues to grow amid ongoing military assaults which rescuers said killed at least 11 people yesterday.

Defence Minister Israel Katz said yesterday Israel would continue preventing aid from entering the besieged territory of 2.4 million people.

"Israel's policy is clear: no humanitarian aid will enter Gaza, and blocking this aid is one of the main pressure levers preventing Hamas from using it

With nowhere safe for Palestinians or those trying to help them, the humanitarian response is severely struggling under the weight of insecurity and critical supply shortages, leaving people with few, if any, options for accessing care."

Amande Bazerolle
MSF coordinator

as a tool with the population," Katz said in a statement.

"No one is currently planning to allow any humanitarian aid into Gaza, and there are no preparations to enable such aid."

Top Israeli officials including Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have repeatedly cited military pressure as the only way to secure the release of the remaining 58 hostages held in Gaza.

Medical aid agency Doctors Without Borders (MSF) said Israeli military operations and the blockade of aid had transformed

Gaza into a graveyard for Palestinians and those who help them.

Critical supply shortages

"Gaza has been turned into a mass grave of Palestinians and those coming to their assistance," said MSF coordinator Amande Bazerolle. "With nowhere safe for Palestinians or those trying to help them, the humanitarian response is severely struggling under the weight of insecurity and critical supply shortages, leaving people with few, if any, options for accessing care," she said.

The United Nations had warned on Monday that Gaza is facing its most severe humanitarian crisis since the war began in October 2023.

"The humanitarian situation is now likely the worst it has been in the 18 months since the outbreak of hostilities," said the UN's Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs.

Israel's renewed assault has so far killed at least 1,630 people in Gaza, the health ministry in the Hamas-run territory reported. So far, at least 51,000 people, the majority of them civilians, have been killed in Gaza in the Israeli offensive, the territory's health ministry said.

— AFP
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Digital push to replace physical Emirates ID

ADVANCED SYSTEM TO DEPLOY FACIAL RECOGNITION AND AI TECHNOLOGIES

ABU DHABI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor

The Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs and Port Security (ICP) has confirmed the development and successful testing of advanced biometric identification systems that eliminate the need for physical Emirates ID cards.

According to the Authority, these advanced systems, built in collaboration with strategic partners, utilise facial recognition and artificial intelligence technologies, accessible via its smart application. These solutions are designed to complement existing identity systems while enhancing security, accuracy, and convenience across sectors.

Target sectors

The biometric ID systems, powered by cutting-edge technology, are designed to be adopted across key sectors such as government, banking, telecommunications, health care, hospitality, and insurance industries where precise and secure customer identification is critical.

These systems apply high standards of technical and procedural verification, while complying with national data protection laws and risk management frameworks. The announcement was made in a

written response to the Federal National Council (FNC), addressing a question from Dr Adnan Hamad Al Hammadi, a member of the Council, about the promotion and implementation of electronic identity solutions to enhance service efficiency.

Strategic roll-out

According to the Authority, the deployment of digital identity solutions is being executed in carefully planned phases. The transition began with the digitisation of simple services to provide immediate benefits to users.

More complex services are now being integrated to ensure a smooth and comprehensive shift toward a fully digital ecosystem.

The Authority noted that the full-scale roll-out of these systems across all sectors is expected to be completed within the next year, with initial focus on services mentioned in the FNC inquiry.

Strategic partnerships are being pursued with leading organisations to incorporate the biometric systems into their platforms, reinforcing the UAE's commitment to global digital leadership.

"Digital identity is not just a tool — it's a gateway to better services, stronger security, and greater convenience for everyone," the Authority stated.



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Pocket watch found on Titanic victim to go on sale

Violin from 1997 movie also up for auction

LONDON

A pocket watch, tickets and money found among the belongings of passengers on the Titanic are among items on sale at a UK auction later this month.

The gilt silver and brass watch was found among the possessions of Danish second-class passenger Hans Christensen Givard, who was among the 1,500 people who died when the vessel sank after hitting an iceberg in 1912.

Givard's pockets contained a savings book, keys, cash in a wallet, a compass,

a passport and the gilded pocket watch, which it is estimated will fetch around £50,000 (\$66,000) at the April 26 auction.

Other items on sale include a letter and medal belonging to first-class Swedish passenger Erik Gustaf Lind and a silver dollar certificate and rare third-class ticket used by Ernest Portage Tomlin.

Both men died in the disaster.

The violin played by the bandleader in the 1997 Hollywood film depicting the sinking is also on sale, and is expected to fetch up to £60,000.

— AFP

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